NPS Wildlife and Backcountry Safety Guide

A practical field reference for wildlife viewing, food storage, trip planning, communication, and backcountry preparedness.

Purpose	Help visitors plan and conduct safer backcountry trips while protecting wildlife and natural resources.	**Core rules**	Maintain wildlife distance, secure food and scented items, plan routes, carry essentials, and know local regulations.
Applies to	National parks and other NPS-managed areas, subject to park-specific requirements.	**Before departure**	Check the specific park website, current conditions, permits, closures, and local safety requirements.

Overview

Wildlife in national parks is wild and unpredictable. The safest approach is to observe animals without approaching, feeding, crowding, or changing their behavior. NPS guidance commonly uses a minimum of 100 yards (91 m) for bears and wolves and 25 yards (23 m) for most other wildlife, but individual parks can establish different requirements. Always follow the rules for the park you are visiting.

Wildlife distance matrix

Wildlife	Common minimum	Visitor action
Bears and wolves	100 yd / 91 m	Do not approach. Increase distance if an animal comes closer.
Other large wildlife	25 yd / 23 m	Includes animals such as bison, elk, moose, deer, and other large animals where the park uses the 25-yard rule.
Park-specific rules	May be greater	Check local regulations. Some parks or areas may require more distance.

The basic backcountry rule

Plan before you go, tell someone where you are going and when you expect to return, carry the Ten Essentials appropriate to your activity, and check the specific park’s conditions and requirements. Backcountry regulations vary by park, including permits, food-storage methods, camping rules, and communication options.

> This guide is a general field reference. It does not replace park-specific regulations or current ranger instructions.

1. Wildlife safety

Keep your distance

Never intentionally approach or follow wildlife. If an animal moves toward you, move away to maintain a safe distance. If your presence changes an animal's behavior, you are too close. Binoculars and telephoto lenses provide safer ways to view wildlife.

Stay alert on trails

Wildlife may be difficult to detect near streams, in dense vegetation, against the wind, or around blind corners and rises in the trail. Look for tracks and scat and be especially attentive when visibility is limited.

Make your presence known where appropriate

In bear country, park guidance may recommend talking, calling out, clapping, or otherwise making noise in areas where surprise encounters are possible. Follow the specific park's bear-safety instructions.

Never feed wildlife

Feeding wildlife can change natural behavior and cause animals to associate people with food. Never intentionally feed wildlife, and do not leave food or trash where animals can obtain it.

Wildlife photography and roadside viewing

Use designated roadside pullouts when stopping to watch or photograph wildlife. Do not block traffic or stop in the road. In Yellowstone, NPS specifically warns visitors not to block traffic for photographs and advises using pullouts.

If an animal approaches

Do not move toward it to obtain a closer view. Increase your distance and keep its travel or escape route clear. Follow the park's species-specific guidance for bears, bison, moose, wolves, mountain lions, and other wildlife.

2. Food storage and camp safety

Store food and scented items

Food storage requirements vary by park and campsite. Where required, use an approved bear-resistant container or other storage system specified by the park. Food storage commonly includes food, beverages, trash, toiletries, sunscreen, soap, medications, and other odorous items.

Keep containers closed

A bear-resistant container works only when it is closed and secured. Do not leave food unattended where wildlife can reach it.

Cook away from sleeping areas

Many park-specific backcountry rules recommend preparing and eating food away from sleeping areas. Follow the distance and storage instructions for the park and campsite you are using.

Leave no food or trash behind

Clean cooking and eating areas thoroughly and pack out trash and food scraps. Never intentionally leave food for wildlife.

Bear canisters are not universal

Some parks require hard-sided bear-resistant canisters, while others permit or require different systems such as food lockers or approved hangs. Check the exact requirement for your destination before departure.

3. The Ten Essentials

The NPS Ten Essentials are organized into ten systems intended to help visitors handle minor injuries, sudden weather changes, and unexpected emergencies. Additional equipment may be necessary for specific activities or environments.

System	Typical items
Navigation	Map, compass, GPS system.
Sun protection	Sunglasses, sunscreen, hat, and other appropriate protection.
Insulation	Extra clothing or layers appropriate to weather and elevation.
Illumination	Headlamp or flashlight with sufficient batteries.
First aid	First-aid supplies and personal medications appropriate to the group.
Fire	Fire-starting equipment where fires are permitted and appropriate.
Repair	Tools and materials for equipment or gear repairs.
Nutrition	Adequate food and emergency food appropriate to the trip.
Hydration	Water and an appropriate purification or treatment method.
Emergency shelter	Lightweight emergency shelter or protection appropriate to conditions.

Additional gear may be appropriate for the activity, including a life jacket, insect protection, satellite messaging device, or specialized equipment. Use the specific park's planning information to build the final packing list.

4. Trip planning

Know where and when

Plan the route, intended destinations or campsites, expected return time, and any permit or reservation requirements. Leave trip information with a responsible person who can act if you do not return as expected.

Build a backup plan

Identify alternative routes, turnaround points, and early exit options. Conditions can change because of wildfire, flooding, snow and ice, storms, trail closures, or other hazards. Do not continue into an area that is closed or unsafe.

Check current conditions

Before departure, check the specific park website and current ranger information for weather, closures, trail conditions, permits, food-storage requirements, water conditions, and other local hazards.

Group information

A useful trip plan can include participant names and contact information, emergency contacts, route and camping details, expected return time, communication methods, and relevant equipment or survival resources.

5. Communication and group safety

Stay together

Keep the group together and establish clear expectations for regrouping, navigation, and decision-making. Do not allow an individual to become separated without an appropriate plan.

Do not rely on cell service

Cellular coverage can be unavailable in remote areas. Check coverage expectations before departure and consider a satellite communicator or other appropriate emergency communication device when the trip enters areas without reliable service.

Battery management

Conserve phone battery for navigation and emergency communication. Carry backup power when appropriate, but remember that a charged device does not guarantee connectivity.

Know when to turn around

Use weather, daylight, trail conditions, group capability, and route changes to decide when to stop or turn back. A backup plan is part of trip preparation, not a sign that the trip has failed.

6. Roadside wildlife safety

Wildlife viewing can create traffic hazards when visitors stop unexpectedly or block roadways. Use designated pullouts and ensure the vehicle is safely out of the travel lane. Follow posted speed limits and remain alert for animals crossing roads.

Photography

Use binoculars or a telephoto lens instead of approaching an animal. Never stop in a blind curve or other unsafe location simply to photograph wildlife.

Wildlife jams

Follow ranger and traffic-control instructions during wildlife concentrations. In Yellowstone, NPS advises visitors to stay with their vehicle when encountering a wildlife jam and to use roadside pullouts for wildlife viewing.

7. Park-specific requirements

NPS parks do not all use identical rules. Food-storage requirements, minimum wildlife distances, permits, camping restrictions, fire rules, communication recommendations, and emergency procedures can differ by location.

Before the trip	Confirm
Wildlife	Species present, required viewing distances, seasonal closures, and species-specific behavior guidance.
Food storage	Bear canister, locker, approved hang, or other required system.
Route	Trail status, closures, conditions, permits, reservations, and turnaround options.
Weather	Forecast, temperature changes, storms, snow/ice, heat, and water conditions.
Communication	Cell coverage, ranger contacts, satellite communication needs, and emergency procedures.

8. Backcountry departure checklist

■ I checked the specific park website for current conditions and closures.

■ I understand the wildlife-distance rules for the park and route.

■ I have a route and expected return time.

■ I have left trip information with a responsible person.

■ I have navigation tools appropriate to the route.

■ I have adequate water and a purification or treatment method.

■ I have food and an emergency food margin appropriate to the trip.

■ I have appropriate layers and emergency shelter.

■ I have first-aid supplies and required personal medications.

■ I have illumination and backup power where appropriate.

■ I have the required food-storage system.

■ I know where cooking and food storage are permitted.

■ I have a backup route or turnaround plan.

■ I know whether cell service is available and have an appropriate communication device.

■ I understand any permit, reservation, fire, pet, or camping restrictions.

9. Wildlife encounter checklist

■ Stop and assess the animal’s location and behavior.

■ Do not approach, follow, feed, or crowd the animal.

■ Increase distance if the animal approaches.

■ Keep the animal’s travel or escape route clear.

■ Use binoculars or a telephoto lens instead of moving closer.

■ Follow species-specific instructions provided by the park.

■ Report unusual or dangerous wildlife interactions to park staff when appropriate.

10. Food and camp checklist

■ All food, drinks, trash, and scented items are accounted for.

■ The required bear-resistant container or food-storage system is available.

■ Containers are closed and secured whenever items are stored.

■ Food is not left unattended.

■ Cooking and eating areas are managed according to local rules.

■ Food scraps and trash are removed.

■ Nothing is intentionally left for wildlife.

■ The campsite is clean before departure.

11. Core principles

Keep your distance. Wildlife is unpredictable and should be observed without changing its behavior.

Keep food secure. Proper storage protects visitors, equipment, and wildlife.

Plan for change. Weather, fire, water, closures, and trail conditions can change during a trip.

Know the park. Local regulations and conditions take precedence over general guidance.

Leave no trace of food or trash. Clean camps help prevent wildlife from associating people with food.

12. Final field reminder

Before entering the backcountry, confirm the current rules for the exact park, trail, campsite, and activity. Carry the equipment appropriate to the conditions, communicate your plans to someone outside the group, and be prepared to turn around when conditions change.